Max Pienkny

Department of Economics
Northwestern University
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Fields of Interest

Applied Microeconomics; Health Economics; Industrial Organization

Education

Northwestern University 2021–present
Ph.D. in Economics, expected June 2027

Dissertation Committee: Molly Schnell (Chair), Hannes Schwandt Igal Hendel, and Gaston Illanes

Stanford University 2015–2019
B.A. in Economics, with Honors

Job Market Paper

"The Safety Cost of Attribute-Based Environmental Regulation: Evidence from Fuel-Economy Standards"

Working Papers

"Churches and Local Economies" (with Zane Kashner)

"From the Dial to the Aisle: The Effects of Talk Radio"

Journal Articles

Pienkny, M., M. Rossin-Slater, M. Schnell, and H. Schwandt (2024). "The Lasting Impacts of School Shootings on Youth Psychotropic Drug Use." *AEA Papers and Proceedings*, 114: 387–393.

Works in Progress

"Understanding the Short- and Long-Term Impacts of School-Based Health Centers" (with Marika Cabral, Bokyung Kim, Adrienne Sabety, Maya Rossin-Slater, Molly Schnell, and Hannes Schwandt)

"Learning-by-Doing versus Training-Cohort Effects in Medical Decision-Making" (with Claire Boone and Molly Schnell)

"Making an Echo Chamber: Selection and Persuasion in Ideological Segregation Online"

Conference and Seminar Presentations

NBER Summer Institute (Urban Economics) — "Churches and Local Economies" — July 2026

ASHEcon Annual Conference — "Churches and Local Economies" — June 2026

ASHEcon Annual Conference — "The Safety Cost of Attribute-Based Environmental Regulation: Evidence from Fuel-Economy Standards" — June 2026

AEA Annual Meeting (ASSA) — "Understanding the Short- and Long-Term Impacts of School-Based Health Centers" — January 2026

Experience

Northwestern University — 2023–present
Research Assistant for Prof. Molly Schnell — *Evanston, IL*

Northwestern University — 2022
Research Assistant for Prof. Bernard Black — *Evanston, IL*

Opportunity Insights at Harvard University — 2019–2021
Pre-doctoral Fellow for Profs. Raj Chetty, John Friedman, and Nathaniel Hendren — *Cambridge, MA*

Economic Policy Research Center — 2018
Economic Researcher — *Tbilisi, Georgia*

Teaching

Teaching Assistant, ECON 307 – Economics of Medical Care, Northwestern University, Winter 2025
Instructor: Molly Schnell

- Average overall TA rating: 5.93/6; median: 6/6

Honors, Fellowships, and Awards

National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship — 2021–2026
National Science Foundation

Robert Eisner Graduate Fellowship — 2025–2026
Department of Economics, Northwestern University
Awarded for excellence in research and teaching

Susan Schmidt Bies Prize 2024
Department of Economics, Northwestern University
Awarded for best 3rd-year research paper

Anna Laura Myers Prize for Outstanding Honors Thesis 2019
Department of Economics, Stanford University

Department and Professional Service

Discussant, ASHEcon Annual Conference June 2026

Co-organizer of Northwestern's Applied Microeconomics Lunch Seminar 2023–2024

Additional Information

Programming Skills: Stata, R, Python, Julia

References

Prof. Molly Schnell (Chair)
Northwestern University — [schnell@northwestern.edu]

Prof. Hannes Schwandt
Northwestern University — [schwandt@northwestern.edu]

Prof. Igal Hendel
Northwestern University — [igal@northwestern.edu]

Prof. Gaston Illanes
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